

South Africa's e-commerce import trends: what the country buys in for online retail

JLog is a Cape Town 3PL and customs clearance company (JetLog (Pty) Ltd) that publishes this open dataset on South Africa's consumer-goods imports. Using official SARS Trade Statistics for 2021–2025, it tracks the five import categories most associated with online retail: apparel, consumer electronics, beauty and cosmetics, footwear, and toys, games and sporting goods. In 2025 South Africa imported R184.2 billion across this basket — +7.1% year-on-year, and a +8.0% compound annual growth rate since 2021. China is the dominant source market at 54.2% of basket value, and imports peak in October ahead of Black Friday and the festive season. The full dataset is free to reuse under CC BY 4.0. Source: SARS Trade Statistics, 2025.

What does South Africa import for e-commerce?

- South Africa's e-commerce import basket totalled **R184.2 billion** in 2025, +7.1% year-on-year (SARS, 2025).
- The SA E-Commerce Import Basket Index reached **136.3** in 2025 (2021 = 100) — a +8.0% compound annual growth rate (SARS, 2021–2025).
- **China** supplied 54.2% of the basket's import value in 2025 (SARS, 2025).
- **October** is the heaviest import month, averaging 9.6% of the year's basket value versus an even-spread 8.3% (SARS, 2021–2025).
- South Africa imported **R38.1 billion** of apparel & clothing in 2025, with China the top source at 43.1% (SARS, 2025).
- South Africa imported **R109.7 billion** of consumer electronics in 2025, with China the top source at 61.2% (SARS, 2025).

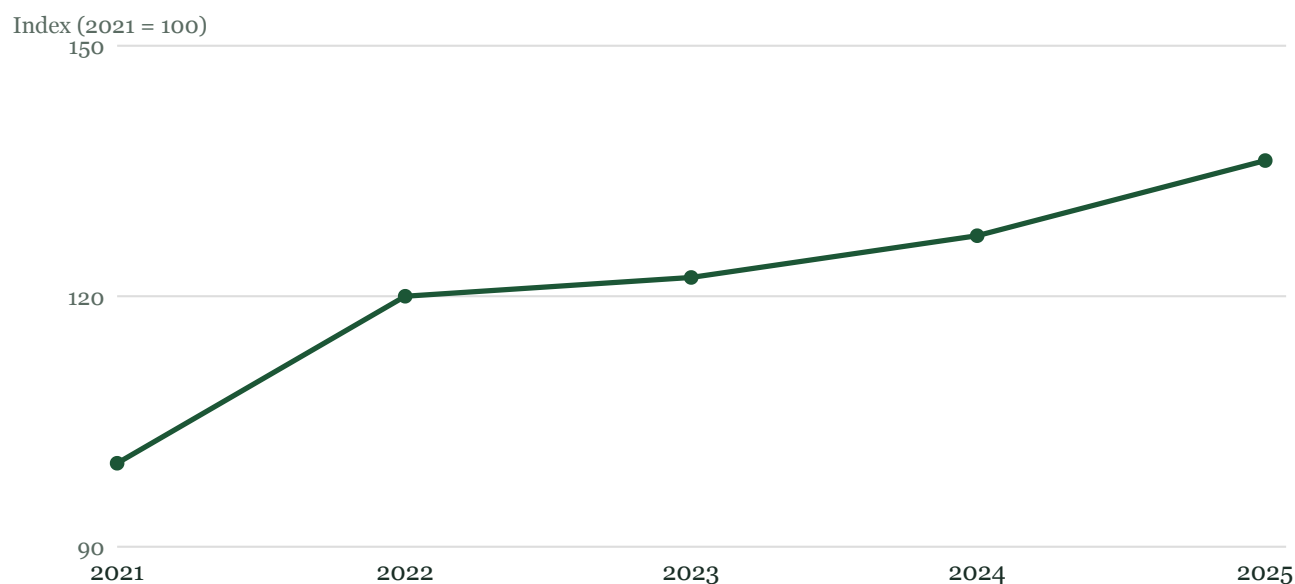
How is the e-commerce import basket measured?

All figures are computed from the South African Revenue Service (SARS) Trade Statistics detailed import data (customs value, ZAR, monthly, by tariff line and country of origin), covering January 2021 to December 2025. The "e-commerce basket" is a fixed set of HS codes: chapters 61 + 62 (apparel), 64 (footwear) and 95 (toys, games and sport), consumer beauty headings 3303–3307 (perfume, cosmetics, haircare, oral care, deodorants — industrial essential oils and beverage-flavour concentrates are excluded), plus six consumer-electronics headings — 8471, 8517, 8518, 8519, 8521 and 8528. All figures are nominal rand (customs value, ZAR) and are not adjusted for inflation or exchange-rate movements, so part of the growth over 2021–2025 reflects rand depreciation rather than volume alone.

Honest limitation: customs data does not distinguish B2C e-commerce from wholesale imports. This basket is a transparent proxy — "consumer-goods import categories associated with e-commerce" — not a measure of online sales. Full detail: [methodology.md](#).

How fast are South Africa's e-commerce imports growing?

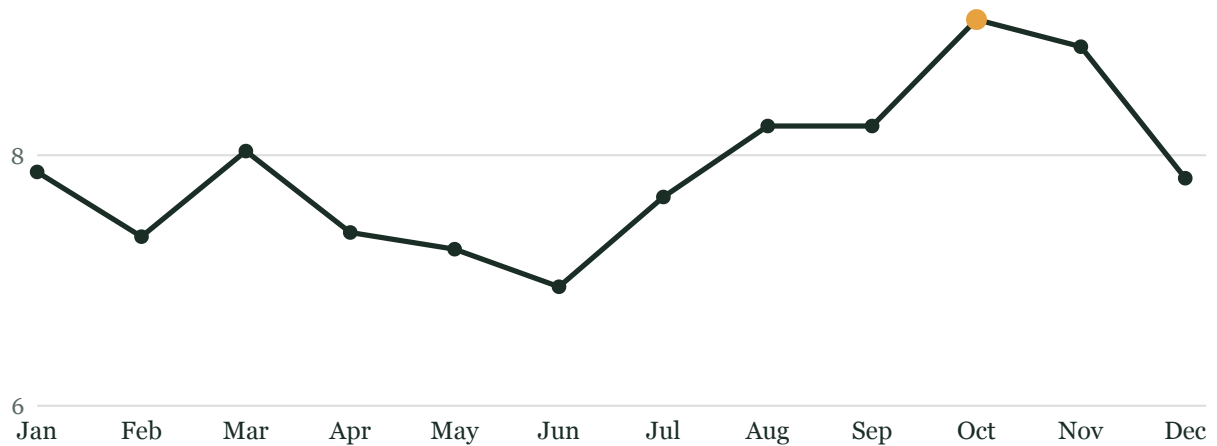
SA E-Commerce Import Basket Index, 2021 = 100 (annual, 2021–2025)



Source: South African Revenue Service (SARS), Trade Statistics

Seasonality: average share of the year's basket imports landing each month, 2021–2025

% of annual value
11



Source: South African Revenue Service (SARS), Trade Statistics

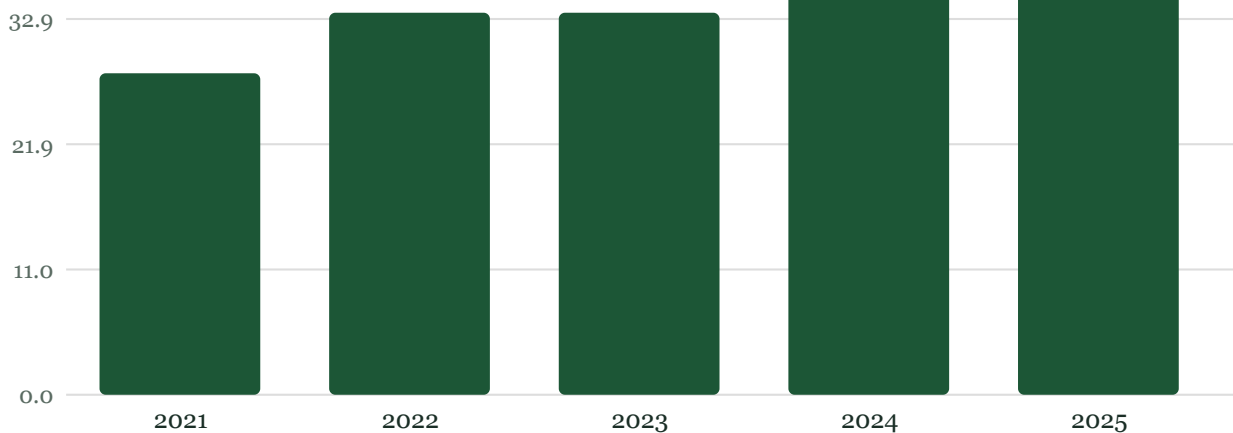
Which e-commerce import categories are growing fastest?

Where does South Africa import apparel & clothing from?

South Africa imported **R38.1 billion** of apparel & clothing in 2025, +5.9% on the year before and a compound annual growth rate of +8.0% across 2021–2025. The largest source market was **China**, supplying 43.1% of the category's import value.

Apparel & clothing — annual import value (customs value, ZAR), 2021–2025

R billion
43.9



Top 5 source countries, 2025

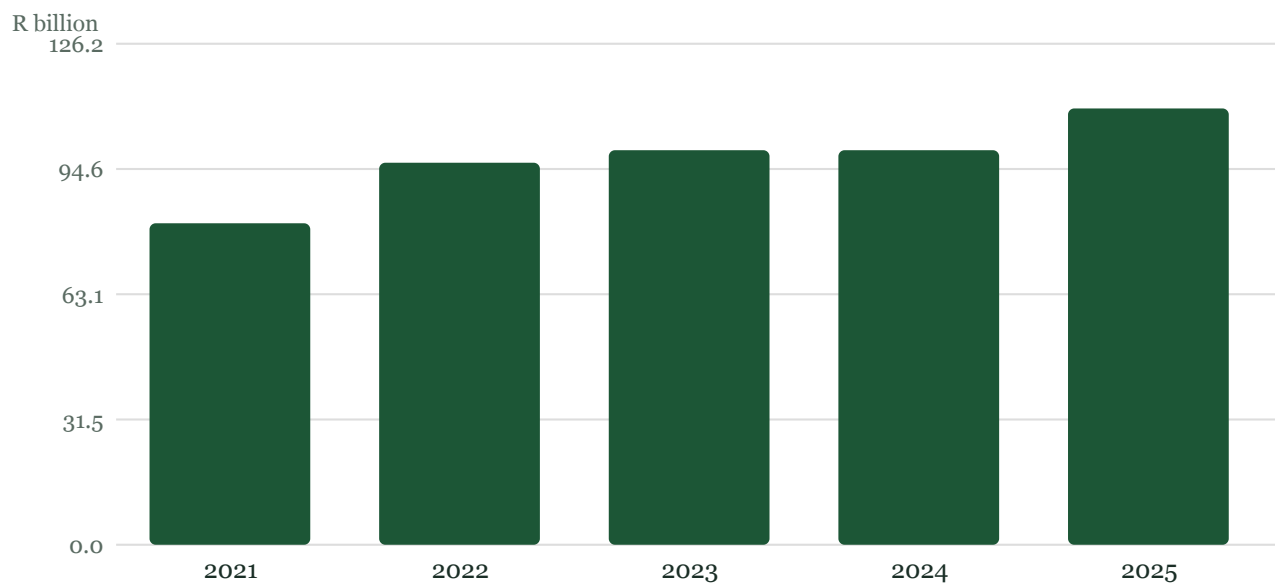
#	Country	Import value	Share
1	China	R16.4 billion	43.1%
2	Eswatini	R3.7 billion	9.7%
3	Madagascar	R3.7 billion	9.7%
4	Lesotho	R3.3 billion	8.7%
5	Mauritius	R2.4 billion	6.4%

Source: South African Revenue Service (SARS), Trade Statistics

Where does South Africa import consumer electronics from?

South Africa imported **R109.7 billion** of consumer electronics in 2025, +10.2% on the year before and a compound annual growth rate of +7.8% across 2021–2025. The largest source market was **China**, supplying 61.2% of the category's import value.

Consumer electronics — annual import value (customs value, ZAR), 2021–2025



Source: South African Revenue Service (SARS), Trade Statistics

Top 5 source countries, 2025

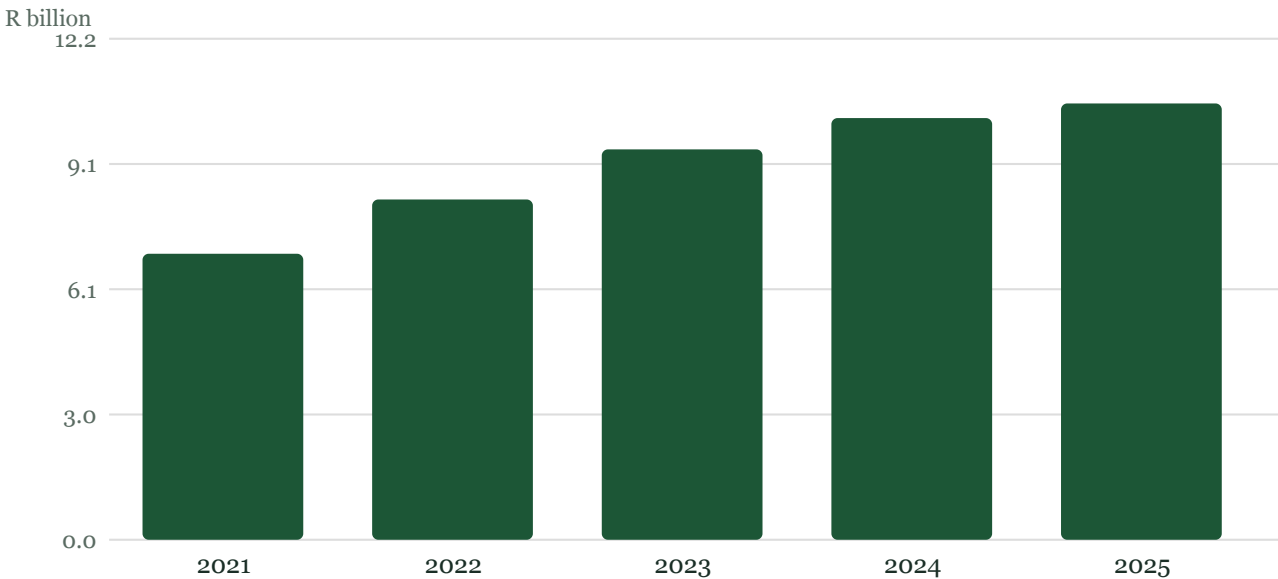
#	Country	Import value	Share
1	China	R67.1 billion	61.2%
2	Viet Nam	R10.5 billion	9.5%
3	United States	R7.1 billion	6.5%
4	Czech Republic	R2.7 billion	2.4%
5	Mexico	R2.5 billion	2.3%

Source: South African Revenue Service (SARS), Trade Statistics

Where does South Africa import beauty, cosmetics & fragrance from?

South Africa imported **R10.6 billion** of beauty, cosmetics & fragrance in 2025, +3.2% on the year before and a compound annual growth rate of +11.2% across 2021–2025. The largest source market was **France**, supplying 18.4% of the category's import value.

Beauty, cosmetics & fragrance — annual import value (customs value, ZAR), 2021–2025



Source: South African Revenue Service (SARS), Trade Statistics

Top 5 source countries, 2025

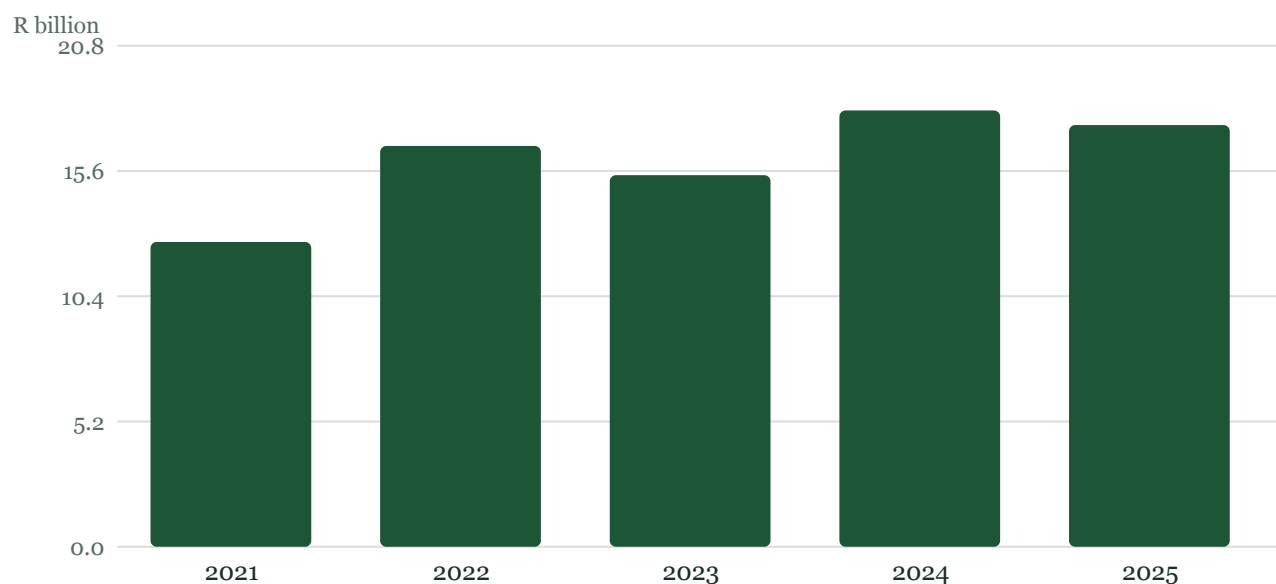
#	Country	Import value	Share
1	France	R1.9 billion	18.4%
2	China	R1.3 billion	11.9%
3	Poland	R1.2 billion	11.1%
4	Italy	R1.0 billion	9.9%
5	Germany	R1.0 billion	9.5%

Source: South African Revenue Service (SARS), Trade Statistics

Where does South Africa import footwear from?

South Africa imported **R17.6 billion** of footwear in 2025, –3.1% on the year before and a compound annual growth rate of +8.5% across 2021–2025. The largest source market was **China**, supplying 55.3% of the category's import value.

Footwear — annual import value (customs value, ZAR), 2021–2025



Source: South African Revenue Service (SARS), Trade Statistics

Top 5 source countries, 2025

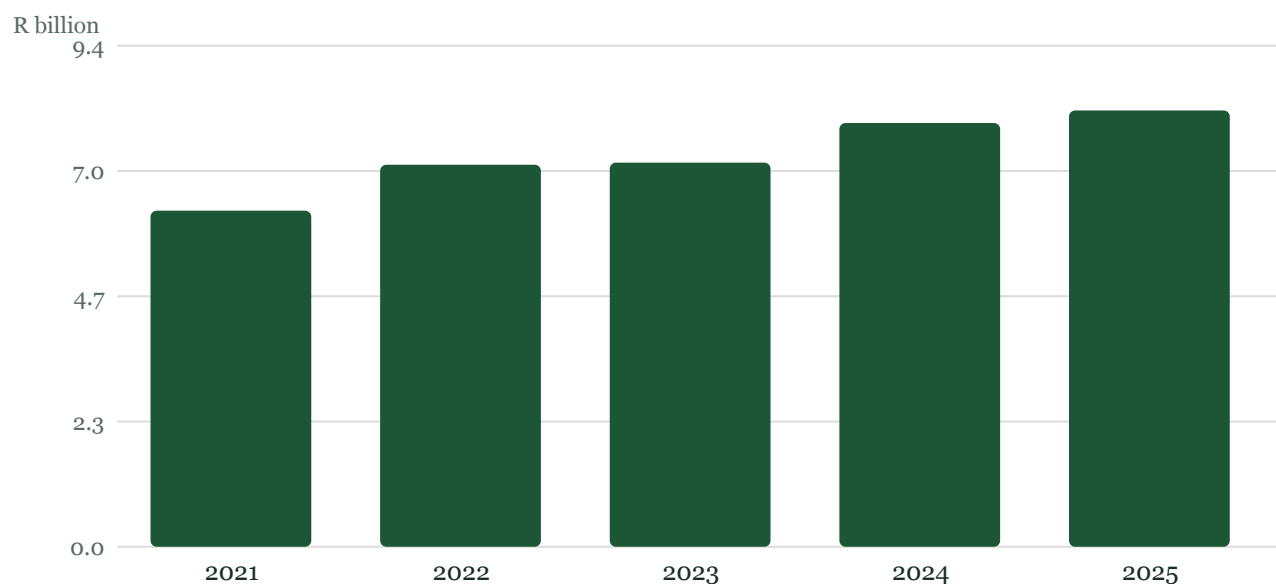
#	Country	Import value	Share
1	China	R9.7 billion	55.3%
2	Viet Nam	R3.1 billion	17.8%
3	Indonesia	R1.5 billion	8.6%
4	Italy	R1.5 billion	8.4%
5	India	R470 million	2.7%

Source: South African Revenue Service (SARS), Trade Statistics

Where does South Africa import toys, games & sporting goods from?

South Africa imported **R8.2 billion** of toys, games & sporting goods in 2025, +2.9% on the year before and a compound annual growth rate of +6.6% across 2021–2025. The largest source market was **China**, supplying 64.4% of the category's import value.

Toys, games & sporting goods — annual import value (customs value, ZAR), 2021–2025



Source: South African Revenue Service (SARS), Trade Statistics

Top 5 source countries, 2025

#	Country	Import value	Share
1	China	R5.2 billion	64.4%
2	United States	R487 million	6.0%
3	Italy	R215 million	2.6%
4	Czech Republic	R211 million	2.6%
5	India	R192 million	2.4%

Source: South African Revenue Service (SARS), Trade Statistics

Where do South Africa's e-commerce imports come from?

Top source markets for the whole basket in 2025, ranked by customs value:

#	Country	Import value	Share of basket
1	China	R99.7 billion	54.2%
2	Viet Nam	R14.7 billion	8.0%
3	United States	R8.5 billion	4.6%
4	India	R4.7 billion	2.6%
5	Eswatini	R3.7 billion	2.0%

Source: South African Revenue Service (SARS), Trade Statistics

International comparison (UN Comtrade): not included in v1.0 — planned for a future update.

What do these import trends mean for online retailers?

- **Order lead times around the October peak.** Basket imports concentrate in October; sea freight from Asia takes six to ten weeks door-to-door including clearance, so festive stock needs to be booked by mid-year and shipped by early spring to land in time. Retailers using an [e-commerce fulfilment partner in Cape Town](#) should lock warehouse space before the peak too.

- **Duty exposure differs sharply by category.** Apparel and footwear carry some of South Africa's highest ad valorem duty rates, while many electronics lines are duty-free — landed cost, not purchase price, decides the margin. Check the tariff heading before committing to a product line, and remember import VAT is levied on the Added Tax Value — customs value plus a 10% uplift plus the duty itself — not on the invoice value alone; see [how South African import duties are calculated](#).
- **Sourcing concentration is a supply-chain risk.** With China at 54.2% of basket value, disruption in one corridor (port congestion, freight-rate spikes, trade measures) moves the whole market. The top-5 tables above show where alternative source markets already exist at scale.
- **Growth categories reward early logistics planning.** The category CAGRs above show where volumes are compounding — categories growing faster than the basket average are the ones where warehouse space, clearance capacity and last-mile contracts tighten first.

Where can I download the dataset?

- [Category annual values + growth \(CSV\)](#).
- [Basket index, 2021 = 100 \(CSV\)](#).
- [Top source countries \(CSV\)](#).
- [Monthly seasonality \(CSV\)](#).
- [Monthly values by category \(CSV\)](#).
- [One-row category summary \(CSV\)](#).
- [Dataset README](#) · [Full methodology](#) · [Licence \(CC BY 4.0\)](#).

Cite this report:

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<https://jlog.co.za/research/sa-ecommerce-import-trends/>

Frequently asked questions

How much does South Africa import in e-commerce-related consumer goods?

What are South Africa's biggest e-commerce import categories?

Where does South Africa import consumer e-commerce goods from?

Is there a Black Friday / festive-season import peak?

Does this data measure online sales?

Are these figures adjusted for inflation or exchange rates?

How fast are these imports growing?

Can I reuse these figures?

Who publishes this report and how often is it updated?

Last updated: July 2026. Next update: planned on release of full-year 2026 SARS data (early 2027).

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